whether Rahul's Bharat Jodo Yatra has had any political impact. For Arvind Kejriwal and the Aam Aadmi Party, it is not the assembly elections in 2023 that will matter—their presence in most of these states is negligible—but how well they are able to govern Punjab, where they swept to power last year, and in their bastion, Delhi. In the south, the big regional party, the Bharat Rashtra Samithi (BRS) headed by K. Chandrashekar Rao, will need a win in the upcoming Telangana election, both for its own and its leader's survival.

The state polls taking place in 2023 can be clustered under four major battles, each with differing impacts. The first battle is for the northeastern states of Tripura, Meghalaya and Nagaland, which kicks off in February. Any win for the BJP and its allies here will be symbolic, the main interest being whether the party will retain Tripura. Rising anti-incumbency saw it replace Biplab Kumar Deb with Manik Saha as chief minister. If the BJP wins all three of these elections, it will continue its dominance in this region—a remarkable feat, given that just six years ago, it was the Congress that was in the driver's seat.

The second battle is the big one, which will see Karnataka going to the polls in May. It is the only southern state that the BJP currently rules, its presence in the other four big states being negligible. Even in Karnataka, its hold is tenuous. In the 2018 election, the BJP emerged as the single largest party with 104 seats—nine short of a simple majority in a house of 224—but it was the Congress with 80 seats and Janata Dal (Secular) with 37 seats that joined forces and formed the government. A year later, the BJP hit back by engineering defections in the Congress and forming the government, with B.S. Yediyurappa as chief minister. Two years later, in July 2021, in a bid to avert the rising anti-incumbency, it replaced Yediyurappa with Basavaraj Bommai. Bommai now faces an uphill task to lead the BJP to victory as party leaders in the state have not quite rallied behind him. The Congress too is wracked by internal strife, with its top leaders, former chief minister Siddaramaiah and state party chief D.K. Shivakumar, at odds with each other. Should they cooperate, though, the Congress has a good chance of pulling off a win that could give it both the momentum and the funds to take on the BJP in the state elections to follow.

The outcome of the Karnataka election will have an important bearing on the third big battle towards the end of 2023, when MP, Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan go to the polls. In 2018, the Congress surprised the BJP by winning all three states, but has lost the advantage since. It conceded MP to the BJP when defections in its ranks led to the fall of the Kamal Nath government. With Shivraj Singh Chouhan serving his fourth term as chief minister, anti-incumbency weighs heavy, as do leadership tussles in the party, though, organisationally, the BJP remains strong. In Rajasthan, the Congress is in trouble, with Chief Minister Ashok Gehlot and his former deputy Sachin Pilot still at war. Things, however, are no better for the BJP, with the tussle for leadership between former chief minister Vasundhara Raje and Gajendra Singh Shekhawat taking a toll on party unity. In Chhattisgarh, the BJP has so far not been able to get its act together to oust the Congress. These three states are crucial in the run-up to the 2024 general election and will put wind in the sails of the party that wins them. The BJP could well argue that despite losing these three states in 2018, it won a majority of their Lok Sabha seats in the 2019 general election. But that was also partly because national security issues prevailed after the Pulwama attack and helped consolidate votes for Modi. There are no such guarantees in 2024 so far.

> MODI'S ADVANTAGE IS THAT HAVING DELIVERED ON THE HINDUTVA FRONT, HE CAN **CONCENTRATE ON KEY DEVELOPMENTAL ISSUES** AND ENHANCE THE BJP'S CHANCES

The fourth big battle is for Telangana, where the BJP has managed to make major inroads, but perhaps not enough to hurt the dominance of the wily KCR, who is seeking a third term, and his party, the rechristened BRS. Unperturbed, the BJP continues to marshal all its forces to unseat KCR, as the state becomes its test case. It is the regional parties that continue to be the party's Achilles heel, whether it is the Mamata Banerjee-led Trinamool Congress in West Bengal, Biju Patnaik's Biju Janata Dal in Odisha, Y.S. Jagan Mohan Reddy's YSR Congress Party in Andhra Pradesh or KCR's BRS in Telangana, all of whom have successfully kept the BJP at bay. While the party has done well in some of these states by displacing the Congress as the prime rival, defeating the regional forces remains it biggest challenge. That has been heightened in Bihar after its ally Nitish Kumar of the JD(U) walked out of the ruling alliance and joined hands with Tejashwi Yadav of the RJD—a formidable combination. In Maharashtra, the BJP may have fought its way back to power by splitting the Shiv Sena, but full control eludes it. The longevity of the breakaway Sena-BJP government will depend on the outcome of the civic polls in the Mumbai/ Thane region this year, which will determine who is the real Sena. The year 2023, therefore, will in many ways be the semi-final for major political parties for the general election in 2024, the last series of big tests before the final examination. ■